Books on Fire and Squirrels in Shredders

a look inside TfL's ban on book swaps and a common institutional failure mode

'Why can't we have nice things?': Fury as London Underground scraps book exchange over 'fire risk' after 20 years



Fury as London Underground book exchange scrapped over 'fire risk' after two decades. *Picture: Social media*

King's Cross, 1987



The Sub-surface Railway Stations Fire Regulation

"All parts of station premises must be kept clear of any accumulation of combustible matter."

— Regulation 7, Fire Precautions (Sub-surface Railway Stations) Regulations 2009

Book Swaps - Actual Risk?



No fires in 20 years

"If you've got a small bookshelf on a platform and in the upstairs area, the risk is there but it's negligible.

- retired LFB Borough Commander Steve Dudeney, speaking to BBC

What happened? January 9th, 2025

b) Track Walks – priority list needed

As above in action section.

6) AOB

a) Silvertown Tunnel

Silvertown tunnel & specifically the action at Commissioners meeting = "ensure that LFB Operational Colleagues are satisfied with plans and to highlight any issues as soon as possible"

Noted. E-bike specific meeting held on 23/1/25 with regards the Silvertown Tunnel bus service.

No actions noted.

b) NOD served on tenant based on Chiswick Park LU station

LFB outlined NOD served and tenants responsibilities to comply with fire safety issues identified with the NOD.

c) TfL to meet LFB to discuss Lewisham DLR station (potential change to it being sub surface)

Discussed. PEL Building Services Fire [redacted] to meet LFB to discuss any potential change. LFB stated would require an action plan on how TfL plan to comply with the sub-surface regulations if the change occur.

d) Lending library(s)

LFB raised concerns about a number of internal lending libraries contained within LU footprint which are not included on the fire plans.

LFB / TfL Liaison Meeting — Any Other Business

What LFB actually said

d) Lending library(s)

LFB raised concerns about a number of internal lending libraries contained within LU footprint which are not included on the fire plans.

LFB did not issue a ban, they just flagged it as part of a routine process, among other things

There is no documented decision from London Fire Brigade (LFB) regarding book clubs. The LFB verbally requested that we review book clubs that were in place to ensure they complied with our own internal procedures for positioning them at a station and they were also captured on the stations' site fire plans.

TfL FOI response: no documented decision from LFB banning book swaps.

What was supposed to happen

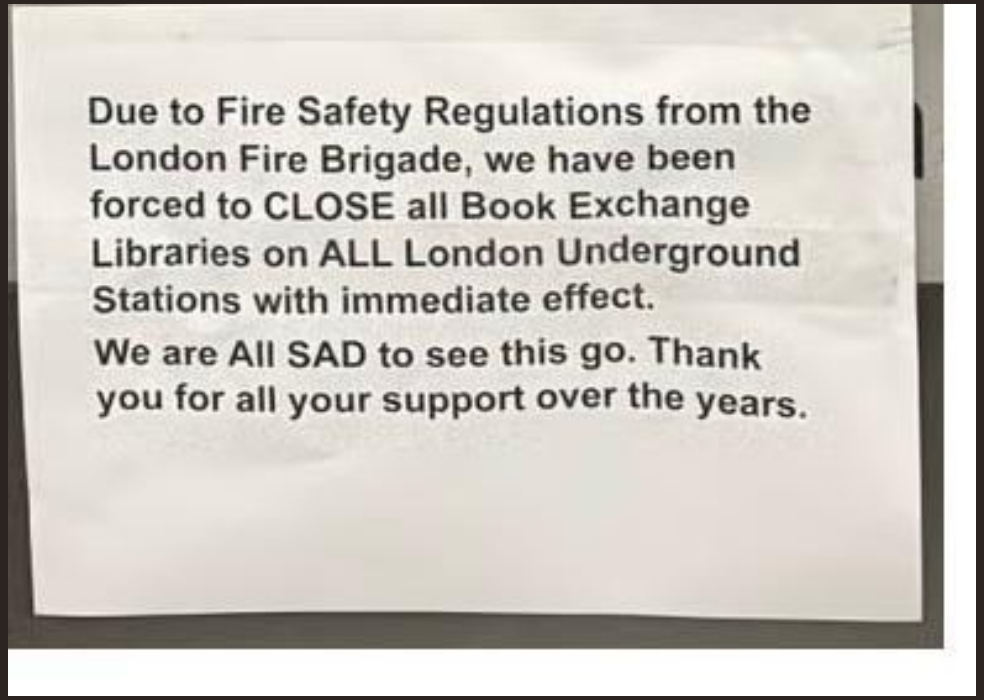
ACTION (15): LU fire lead Area Manager [redacted] to create a TfL lending library policy based on location, fire risk and LFB guidance – by 01/03/2025.

ACTION (16): LU fire lead Area Manager [redacted] to review all rail locations to ensure the policy as per action 15 is compliant – by 15/3/25

Action 15: Create a policy. Action 16: Review all locations.

Deadlines: 1 March and 15 March 2025.

What actually happened



"Someone has taken the legislation to the nth degree without using experience and skill to use a proper assessment of the risk."

— Steve Dudeney
former LFB Borough Commander

Accountability Sinks

> *A structure where human judgement gets replaced by process.*
>
> Nobody decides anything: the system produces an outcome and everyone points at everyone else.
>
> — Dan Davies, The Unaccountability Machine

How institutional systems shredded 440 Squirrels



News

Airline killed 440 squirrels in `giant shredder'

Gary Finn

Friday 16 April 1999 00:02 BST

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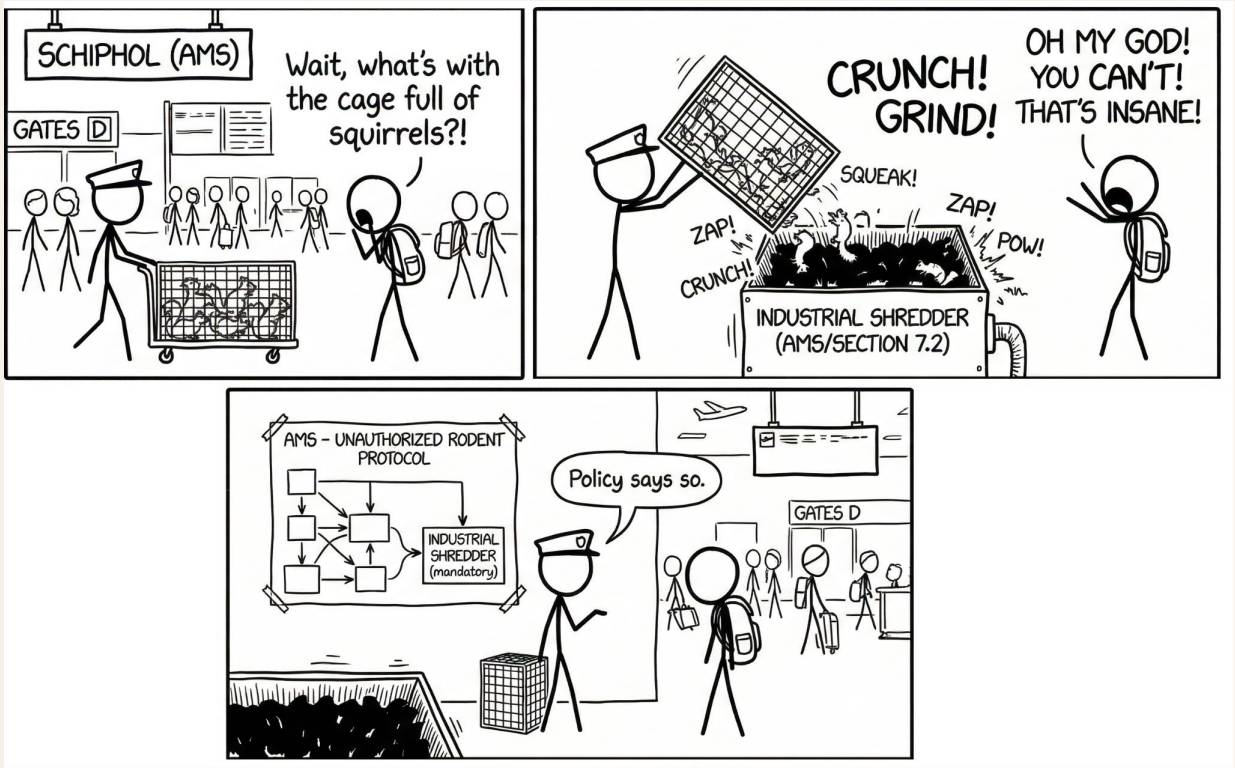
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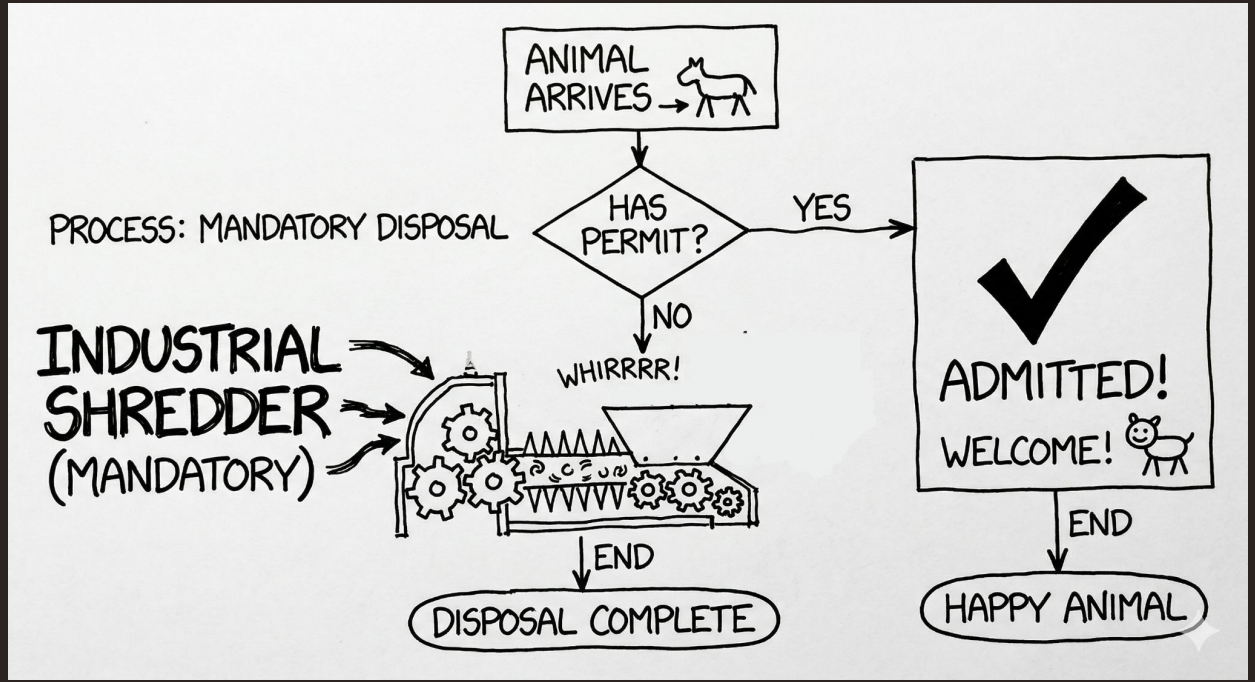
HAND-FEEDING more than 400 live squirrels into a giant shredding machine may sound like a plot from a straight-to-video horror movie, but to the airline KLM Royal Dutch it was a normal procedure.

Yes, that's right, live squirrels



Not a Real XKCD Comic - Inspired by Randall Munroe - made with Google Gemini

Regulations can limit discretion and prescribe specific courses of action in pre-defined circumstances



this makes managers' lives easier and stops random vibes-based decisions

However, sometimes that Course of Action involves shredding nice things

~31

stations with book swaps

Only

~15

were sub-surface

The prescriptive no-combustibles regulation only applies to sub-surface stations.
A risk-based approach was always legally available for the majority.

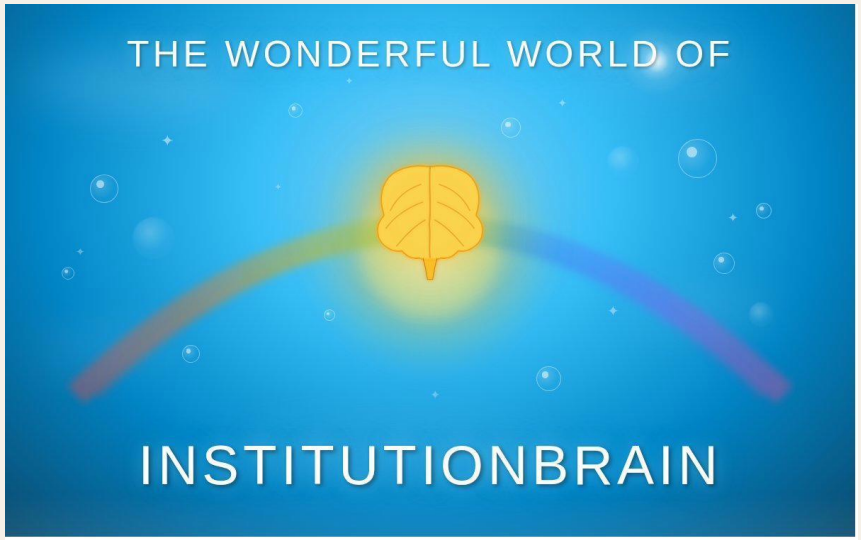
At the airport, there genuinely was no discretion available in the system

For the Book Swaps, there was - Why wasn’t it used?

We do not value discretion, curiosity, and care in our Middle Managers / Bureaucrats

My revised theory

- Whoever got assigned those actions saw a problem outside their usual context
- Not in their annual plans or quarterly plans or plan plans, and not in their day-to-day workflow.
- The institutional ‘stomp reflex’ kicked in: ban it, say it’s due to LFB regulations (hence out of your hands), move on.
- They didn't anticipate so many people would care.



A lot of people cared

- *FOI requests filed*
- *National media coverage*
- *Public fury on social media*
- *Mayoral intervention*

What's happening now



Metal enclosure. On fire plans. 1.5m from combustibles. Unpaid side of gate line. Approx £2000 each.

Discretion is key to having nice things

In the context of how we design our institutions,

We need people with the spare capacity, curiosity, and care to use discretion, and empower them



Pressure your Local Bureaucrats

In the context of being a member of the public who likes things; **pressure works**

